UNBALANCED DIET

India is home to 25% of the world's undernourished people. Even in the best states, figures are high, but gap is stark between toppers and laggards

BEST 5 IN NUTRITION

1. Kerala **15.29**
2. Punjab **22.11**
3. Tamil Nadu **24.8**
4. Andhra Pradesh **26.38**
5. Himachal Pradesh **27.18**



BOTTOM 5 IN NUTRITION

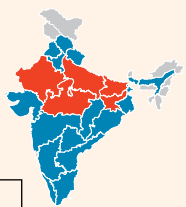
1. Bihar **51.88**
2. Jharkhand **47.99**
3. Madhya Pradesh **45.49**
4. Uttar Pradesh **44.47**
5. Chhattisgarh **43.02**

Percentage of population deprived of nutrition
Source: NITI Aayog's Multidimensional Poverty Index, 2021

UNEVEN POPULATION GROWTH

Fertility rates remain high among BIMARU states

LARGE STATES WITH LOWEST TFR*



Punjab, West Bengal — 1.6
Andhra Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Maharashtra — 1.7
Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Telangana — 1.8
Haryana, Uttarakhand, Assam, Gujarat — 1.9

LARGE STATES WITH HIGHEST TFR*

Bihar — 3
Uttar Pradesh — 2.4
Jharkhand — 2.3
MP, Rajasthan — 2

*Source: NFHS-5; *TFR: Total fertility rate (children per woman)*

60% Indians can't afford a nutritious diet, a majority of them in states in the Hindi heartland and the east

1.4 The fertility rate in Jammu & Kashmir, the lowest in India

tal education, which necessitated purchase of mobile phones or laptops and subscription to internet data plans, added to the expenses.

In a pandemic year hit by massive job losses, the budgetary allocation on education and healthcare was expected to go up. State expenditure on education has hovered around 3 per cent of GDP between 2014 and 2019, against the historic target of 6 per cent. Other middle-income countries spent more—Brazil 6.1 per cent, Russia 4.7 per cent and South Africa 6.8 per cent. These countries also had more allocation to healthcare in terms of GDP compared to India's 3.5 per cent—Brazil 9.5 per cent, Russia 5.3 per cent and South Africa 8.2 per cent. While the pandemic situation saw the Union government hike the budgetary allocation on healthcare by 28 per cent in this budget (compared to 2020-21), the allocation to the education ministry increased by only 5 per cent for the same period. In fact, the budgetary allocation had dropped from Rs 99,311.5 crore in 2020-21 to Rs 93,224.3 crore in 2021-22 despite the government launching the New Education Policy in 2020.

Yet, several poorly performing states have sought to amend things by allocating higher funds to education and healthcare. According to the NITI Aayog's Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI) released last year, Bihar and Assam, even with 52 per cent and 33 per cent of population that is multidimensionally poor, have been spending significantly on education and healthcare. In fact, Assam has been a top spender among large states in both education and healthcare. The results are showing. Assam has emerged as the second-best state to show incremental improvement in healthcare in NITI Aayog's Health Index, 2019-20.

Similarly, Uttar Pradesh has shown the most improvement—from the base year (2018-19) to reference year (2019-20)—on various health outcome indicators. However, such incremental improvements pale as the gaps in overall performance between the top five states and the bottom five are striking. If the percentage of population that is multidimensionally poor is 52 per cent in Bihar, it's less than 1 per cent in Kerala.

This gap in poverty is reflected in the